Who Are We?

Social Identity Theory in Campus Life



How campus labels shape belonging and bias

第 6 组 | GROUP 6

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Which label comes first?

Think of one label you used in your first week on campus.

HOMETOWN	Local	Non-local
PERSONALITY	Introvert	Extrovert
CAMPUS LIFE	Major	Club

When does a label become a judgment?

Part of “I” comes from “we”

Group identities shape how we see ourselves and other people.

SOCIAL IDENTITY

The part of self-concept connected with valued group memberships.

OUR CLAIM

Labels support belonging.
They can also narrow judgment.

Tajfel & Turner (1979); APA Dictionary of Psychology, “Social identity theory.”

Three mechanisms, one campus

01 → 02 → 03

Categorization

Who is “us”?

A hometown accent

Identification

Where do I belong?

A running group

Comparison

How do “we” compare?

Our major vs. theirs

Connected mechanisms, not a fixed sequence. Campus cases are illustrative.

Framework: Tajfel & Turner (1979); social influence extension: Turner & Oakes (1986).

Categorization: a familiar accent

CAMPUS SCENARIO

“You sound like you’re from Xuzhou.”

A cue of possible shared membership



A QUICK SOCIAL MAP

“One of us”

Accent tells us little about ability, interests, or character.

A useful social shortcut can hide individual differences.

Even small boundaries can matter

MINIMAL GROUP STUDY

GROUP LABELS

Relatively trivial group distinctions

➡

DECISION

Distribution of rewards

➡

FINDING

Favoritism toward the ingroup

A simple group boundary can influence reward decisions.

A tendency in a controlled setting; not a rule about every person or campus.

Tajfel, Billig, Bundy, & Flament (1971). European Journal of Social Psychology. doi:10.1002/ejsp.2420010202

Identification: becoming “one of us”

Joining a running group



“I will go once.”

“I am a runner.”

“This is our routine.”

Valued group norms can become personal standards.

Comparison: how good is “our” group?

HYPOTHETICAL CLAIM

“Our major is more practical than theirs.”

SELF-ENHANCEMENT

A favorable view of “us”

ASK FOR EVIDENCE

Better in what respect?

Tajfel & Turner (1979). The student claim is hypothetical; no major ranking is asserted.

Belonging has a boundary

WHAT IT CAN OFFER

- Belonging
- Encouragement
- Shared purpose

WHAT IT CAN COST

- Exclusion
- Pressure to conform
- Stereotypes

Value your community. Stay curious about people beyond it.

A label is a starting point

ONE CLASSROOM CASE

“Quiet”

A behavior in
a particular setting



WHAT ELSE COULD WE LEARN?

A careful listener

An experienced researcher

Someone with an idea to share

Ask about interests, experience, and opportunities to participate.

From English learner to English user

A LIMITING SELF-DESCRIPTION

“I am only a learner.”



A POSSIBILITY FOR PARTICIPATION

“I can contribute an idea.”

Social relationships can shape opportunities to use English.

Participation still needs vocabulary, practice, feedback, and support.

Related language-learning research: Norton Peirce (1995). TESOL Quarterly. doi:10.2307/3587803

Three habits for a wider “we”

01	**Notice the label**	What do I actually know about this person?
02	**Seek another connection**	Which interests or goals might we share?
03	**Make participation possible**	Whose idea have we not yet invited?

Identity is also about “we”

Groups can shape belonging.
Labels should not define the whole person.

CATEGORIZE

Organize the social world

IDENTIFY

Make membership meaningful

COMPARE

Position “us” in relation to others

Thank you.

Which campus label would you rethink?

What would you want to know about the person behind it?

QUESTIONS & IDEAS



References / Theory and classic evidence

01 Tajfel, H., & Turner, J. C. (1979). An integrative theory of intergroup conflict. In W. G. Austin & S. Worchel (Eds.), The social psychology of intergroup relations (pp. 33–47). Brooks/Cole.

https://glottolog.org/resource/reference/id/668195

02 Tajfel, H., Billig, M. G., Bundy, R. P., & Flament, C. (1971). Social categorization and intergroup behaviour. European Journal of Social Psychology, 1(2), 149–178.

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03 American Psychological Association. (n.d.). Social identity theory. APA Dictionary of Psychology.

https://dictionary.apa.org/social-identity-theory

References / Identity and language

04 Turner, J. C., & Oakes, P. J. (1986). The significance of the social identity concept for social psychology with reference to individualism, interactionism and social influence. British Journal of Social Psychology, 25(3), 237–252.

https://doi.org/10.1111/j.2044-8309.1986.tb00732.x

05 Norton Peirce, B. (1995). Social identity, investment, and language learning. TESOL Quarterly, 29(1), 9–31.

https://doi.org/10.2307/3587803

Campus examples are illustrative. No original survey or major ranking is presented.